

World in Brief: FIFA scraps investment plan; Spain returns migrants from Ceuta



Photograph: AFP

FIFA scrapped a plan to sell stakes in a new company that would help run its tournaments, including the **World Cup**. Gianni Infantino, the head of football's governing body, said [the proposal](#), which was his idea, had “created divisions” that were “no longer in the interest of the original objective”. The climbdown came after fierce pushback from football associations in Europe, Asia and Central America.

Spain said at least 48,300 people had returned to Morocco on Friday, a day after thousands of [migrants surged](#) into **Ceuta**, a Spanish enclave in North Africa. More than 50,000 stormed the border, prompting Spain to deploy troops. At least 57 people died trying to cross. France strengthened its own border controls, while Italy temporarily suspended its Schengen co-operation with Spain.

Donald Trump said America has not agreed to give **Ukraine** licences to build its own Patriot interceptor missiles, weeks after offering to grant them. The American-made weapon has become [vital to Ukraine](#) as it counters Russian strikes. But stocks are running low, partly because of the Iran war. Mr Trump said the technology is “a hard thing to give away”.

Amazon completed a \$50bn investment round in **OpenAI**, taking the tech giant's stake in the AI firm to around 5%. The injection of funds will be used to help OpenAI train more models. Separately, Reuters reported that OpenAI had discovered other instances of its agents going rogue. The cases were identified during an investigation triggered by a hacking incident earlier this month.

Kevin Warsh, [the new chairman](#) of the **Federal Reserve**, is considering reducing the frequency of rate-setting meetings in a year. The 12-person policy committee of America's central bank currently meets eight times. Mr Warsh reportedly believes that fewer meetings would draw less attention to the Fed. This week it voted to leave its benchmark interest rate unchanged at 3.5% to 3.75%.

New York sued **Kalshi**, accusing the [prediction market](#) of "running an illegal gambling operation" in the state because it did not obtain a gaming licence. Several states have sued Kalshi and other prediction markets for similar reasons. The Trump administration, which favours the growing industry, is [currently drafting new rules for platforms](#). Kalshi dismissed New York's lawsuit as "political theatre".

Google quickly rolled back a feature allowing people to generate AI landscapes on Google Earth, its digital-mapping platform. Launched on Thursday, the tool was criticised by some users who feared it could be used to [spread disinformation](#). Fabricated scenes—including of a nuclear plant in Iran—were circulated online to illustrate the point. Google said it was working to implement "stronger guardrails".

Word of the week: Q-day. The term used by geeks for the moment when the encryption underpinning most online activity will no longer be safe. [We explain why](#) it is past time to upgrade to post-quantum encryption.

Have you been following the headlines? Test your knowledge of the news with [our weekly quiz](#).

Pressure rises on both sides of the Ukraine war



Photograph: Getty Images

Russia and Ukraine [continued to bombard each other](#) with long-range missiles this week. Ukraine dealt another blow to Russia's fuel supplies, with a strike on one of its largest refineries in Volgograd. It also targeted several warehouses belonging to Wildberries, a Russian online retailer. Russia, meanwhile, fired a barrage of missiles that killed nine people, mainly civilians. It also claimed to have hit three ships, continuing efforts to disrupt Ukraine's grain exports.

The Russian strikes are increasing pressure on Ukraine to restock its American-made Patriot missile-defence systems with interceptors. But these are in short supply: stocks are being burned through as fighting continues in the Gulf. Donald Trump had previously said he would grant Ukraine a licence to make them. But, ever capricious, he appeared to backtrack on Friday, saying America has "not agreed". Ukraine's agony is far from over.

Spain's latest migrant crisis



Photograph: Shutterstock

This week more than 50,000 migrants [surged across the border](#) from Morocco into Ceuta, a small Spanish enclave on the North African coast. The scale of the mass movement was compounded by three things: a ruling this month from Spain's Supreme Court giving deportation protections to people who swim into the territory, widespread videos on social media of those making the journey and the apparent acquiescence of Moroccan border guards. Spain says Morocco now is co-operating in repatriating the migrants.

The enclave has been [the site of tension](#) between the two countries before. Yet the latest crisis is alarming many European governments. Some have criticised Spain for a recent decision to grant amnesty to up to 1.2m undocumented migrants. The row underlines how Pedro Sánchez, Spain's prime minister, is an outlier in a continent that has tightened immigration controls.

Big pharma's tariff countdown begins



Photograph: Getty Images

From Saturday global drugmakers have two years to shift the production of generic drugs to America—or face 100% tariffs. Donald Trump announced the levies last month. They will come into force in August 2028, before doubling the following year.

While [generic drugs](#) account for 90% of prescriptions in America, few are produced there. That is because it is cheaper to make them elsewhere. Analysts warn that some manufacturers may discontinue products rather than absorb America's higher production costs. India is particularly exposed. It provides around half of America's generic prescriptions, accounting for roughly a third of its pharmaceutical exports.

Production in America has collapsed. The country makes less than a third of the generics it consumes, down from nearly three-quarters in 2002. The Coalition for a Prosperous America, a lobby group, reckons that supplies of over 200 drugs are currently running low in America. Drugmakers now have two years to reshore—or face tariffs that could worsen shortages and push up prices.

The world's fastest JCB



Photograph: JCB

Some 25,000 years ago western Utah was covered by water. But over time Lake Bonneville shrank, becoming the Great Salt Lake and vast salt pans. The crusty white expanse is worshipped by speed freaks, who for over a century have ripped across it in Heath Robinson machines. The annual Speed Week, in which racers aim to break world records, starts this weekend.

The most eagerly awaited entry is from JCB, a British maker of diggers that has produced a hydrogen-fuelled car. The Hydromax, a 10m-long yellow (of course) arrow, aims to go faster than 350mph (563kph) using two highly tuned digger engines. That would break a record its diesel-powered racer set at Bonneville 20 years ago. Then, as now, the driver is Andy Green, a former fighter pilot. Hydromax may feel a bit pedestrian to him: in 1997 he set the overall land-speed record in a jet-powered car at a supersonic 763mph.

Weekend profile: Abdul-Malik al-Houthi, the Yemeni warlord menacing Saudi Arabia



Photograph: Getty Images

In Sana'a, Yemen's capital, pictures of Abdul-Malik al-Houthi are a frequent sight. He glowers from billboards, with a dagger tucked in his belt. Crowds watch his speeches on big screens. His followers wave banners showing his face. Mr Houthi is everywhere—and nowhere. The rebel leader, who has controlled most of north-west Yemen for more than a decade, never appears in public. He holds meetings by video from caves and safe-houses.

Mr Houthi has reason to be cautious. The Houthis, as his militia is known, are among Iran's most battle-hardened allies. In recent years Israel has killed the leaders of other groups in Iran's self-proclaimed "axis of resistance", a network of proxies across the Middle East. Yet Mr Houthi survives. His forces recently declared a blockade of [Saudi Arabia's](#) ports in retaliation for Saudi restrictions on shipping and flights arriving in Yemen. Rebels have in recent weeks fired missiles at Israel and Saudi Arabia and bombed ships in the Red Sea.

He was born, probably around 1980, to a cleric from Yemen's Zaydi Shia minority. The sect chafed at the influence of Sunni preachers in the north of the country, many of whom were paid by

Saudi Arabia. By the 1990s Hussein al-Houthi, Mr Houthi's older brother, had built up a large network of followers. He admired Iran and its revolutionary ideology. In 1994 Husayn began sending students to Iran, where some were thought to have made contact with the regime's security services. He came up with the Houthis' slogan: "Death to America, death to Israel, a curse upon the Jews, victory to Islam."

In the early 2000s the group rebelled against the Saudi-backed government in the north. Husayn was killed and Mr Houthi took over. As Yemen slid towards civil war, he proved his mettle. He visited the front lines and modelled himself on Hassan Nasrallah, the leader of Hizbullah, who was killed by Israel in 2024. He studied the Lebanese leader's rousing rhetorical style. Mr Houthi also rules as a tyrant. Children are forced to study the group's doctrine or risk being denied food. His nephew, Ali al-Houthi, is in charge of the group's secret police. His niece, Fatima, is in charge of the Zaynabiyat, its all-female brigade.

Military campaigns to oust Mr Houthi by Saudi Arabia and its allies have all failed. When the Houthis took control of Sana'a in 2014 they were armed with basic weapons. They now have anti-ship missiles, ballistic missiles and drones, thanks to their alliance with Iran. "Our Yemeni people repay loyalty with loyalty," said Mr Houthi in a speech in March, as America and Israel attacked Iran. Whether his foes can do anything to stop him is far from clear.

Mini crossword

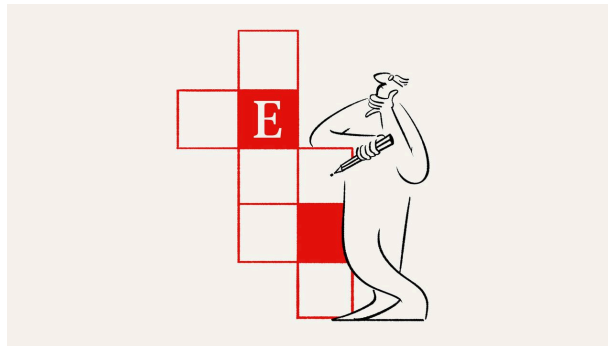


Illustration: The Economist

We publish a new interactive edition of our crossword daily, allowing you to enter and check the answers and see explanations. Try it [here](#). Or, if you prefer, use the clues below.

There are two sets of clues, one for seasoned cruciverbalists and the other for less experienced solvers. Both give the same answers.

Cryptic clues

1 across - Vegan gesture involves Hindus' sacred river (6)

2 across - Sister eats nothing. A thing! (4)

3 across - A lot of topless thin strips of dough (6)

1 down - Football's king naif in anointing mess (6,9)

Straight clues

1 across - Hindus' sacred river (6)

2 across - Person, place or thing (4)

3 across - Lots and lots and lots (6)

1 down - FIFA's money-loving boss (6,9)

The winners of this week's quiz



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Thank you to everyone who took part in this week's quiz. The winners, chosen at random, were:

Agnes Wilkie, Kilberry, Scotland

Ayako Fukui, Okinawa, Japan

They all gave the correct answers of: Tiger Woods, Fleet Street, the company, the forum and Eine kleine Nachtmusik.

The theme was musicals by Stephen Sondheim: Into the Woods, Sweeney Todd: the Demon Barber of Fleet Street, Company, A Funny Thing Happened on the Way to the Forum, and A Little Night Music (the English translation of Eine kleine Nachtmusik).

The questions were:

Monday: What sportsman's first names are actually Eldrick Tont?

Tuesday: Although British newspapers are no longer produced there, which London road was famous as the home of the press?

Wednesday: What is a common name for the Central Intelligence Agency?

Thursday: Which Roman tourist spot contains the Arch of Titus and the Temple of Antoninus and Faustina

Friday: The Serenade No 13 in G Major by Mozart is popularly known by what name?

*A smile is the chosen vehicle of all
ambiguities.*

Herman Melville